

ASSIGNMENT 1: ANCIENT CRYPTO

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1 The Index of Coincidence (IC)

[20 pts] Question 1 For each of Caesar, affine, Vigenère, and Playfair, is the IC of the ciphertext expected to be higher, lower, or equal to the plaintext's IC? Explain why.

Caesar: equal

Explanation: Caesar cipher shifts every letter by a fixed number. Since each plaintext letter is mapped to exactly one ciphertext letter, the letter frequencies remain unchanged, and therefore the IC stays the same.

Affine: equal

Explanation: Affine cipher uses a one-to-one substitution, mapping each plaintext letter to a unique ciphertext letter. This preserves the letter frequency distribution, so the IC remains unchanged. This mapping is a permutation of the alphabet.

Vigenère: lower

Explanation: Vigenère cipher uses different shifts depending on the position of the letter in the repeating key. Therefore, the same plaintext letter can be encrypted into different ciphertext letters, making the letter frequency distribution more uniform and generally reducing the IC. If the key length is 1, Vigenère reduces to Caesar and the IC is unchanged.

Playfair: lower

Explanation: Playfair cipher encrypts pairs of letters rather than individual letters. The encryption of each letter depends on the other letter in its pair. This disrupts the original single-letter frequency distribution, making it generally more uniform and reducing the expected IC.

2 Detecting Ciphers

[30 pts] Question 2 Without breaking them, which line of `ciphertexts_i.txt` corresponds to which cipher? Explain how you figured out each one.

The six lines of `ciphertexts_80.txt`:

1) PRWAKPWAGBQYBHDWPSNQPOWKZZQYCINQDQMAHFZMQMUZPDIUMQLFNBRLONCZYCHUQBRLPGBOGPRGDPTVQWHABAGPWQBQHVHVMMG
KFRGXPKMGPHUVYLMFLSMBNKFHVVMQTDPSYCWBMKXKFZQZRXHWCLBWHRQDVUMFTQKLDPVCFDFOBUIBQGCXHBQSRESMYOMUKDPYPDPT
VDPNUXQQBBEHPONFZOZKOZNLONCHWKOLUZGPPYVBMQHKONVSURXPCSFUVUMQTDPSDPZAOGUMMQHTBOHGHDXKNVGPHTMQMU

2) GZCKPFCAPCRWSGHFQBGHWCBOBRAOHIFWHMKWHVWHGQOZARSASOBCFOBRJJCZJWBUOPWZWHWSGWHRSACBGHFOHSGHVOHUFCKHVF
SEIWFSGPCHVORODHOHWCBOBROQQSDHOBQSGZCKPFCHSOQVSGHVQHVOBUSQOBPFWBUBSKGHFSBUHVGVWHFSTZSQHGHVSWADCFHOBQSCT
DOHWSBQSOBRHWAUBGVCKWBUBHVOHHFISRSJSZCDASBHPQOZOBQSGQCBHWHBIWHMKWHVHFOBGTCTFAOHWC

3) B3P3R6IFG5Q7SOUUMDKFFFMPZ2SKKXHYT2F6DZB2EFSXDTI3WEI542Q4X4UYYPVMID0ZW4MBXXDUGNGNEILQLXNMADQQ55YIQT3J
D5Y4QOLOPJRMIS30CV2YENQFMJP4IAJINJJP7LYM2RWQIKZEZL4K7PFVYJOSTEVWQ6AL4T6B34HHJ20C7PFTNCBHSQ4VYPBIMGYKZ
6RK3BEMXP5T2ZAWBTTJKOAKBWFNUCCGHG7YOFBTVJT5H4FA76JU5TPZM4XP24GAFLQUANIWGV7CCLTS02LIQAL2PIBGSOWIWKYKQCHY
ZLE2

4) F6ADXSKGN5QCHHVCOUJ4PIIVKPDJYKIOUQS34SXXS3ISIO3MIEXSQZ2JYDNAV6XVOZWAM6HNQFCTQMXVR65RRRLRVT3UHN4P2J
D7VTABKYDLHA7YK5DIEND3DHG06L20JCEEBTPS6YKVD4RWCTMVH7DNYDXZOMCOEQHFLBMQ4OBNAARJPIPPNEFEJUFVDA3D6X6GKSMH
SC7LEPUVAJLLXRCO4SNR5KKB5OE7UTVCZAUJFTHNZK2LFW2KJXWAFPKXU4WJRX56WKUNI

5) NFYVCLEJQDEQDJDSCJEQDRBJBLSFSKJNBGGHBCIJIFQEGBZYJFSKWLVRJDKZLCBLSBCKDZLSJCQFCDJZFJCDQTCIQLVPIEQFRCBR
DFSKQDWBSDZDSCNFYVCLEJCDFRIDJCIFCRLSJBBCDSCDWLQCFSKFKFECFYBGBCTGDFKCLDWBRBDSRTBCQDWGDRCJKBJRBEGBSDFPB
GBCTFSKJCQFCDPBRREFYBGBCTNFYVCLEJDZYLKBDJJNBGGQDWBSDZDSCFSKRLSCQLGGDKJCQDSPCT

6) CUGFEKEHEEBFTCEKCFBFATOIQINIGNRDXXSNVHAYXOICYDXRFGUDTZFEMNZJMILDVCINKTIQNEKTYUJOOEIEZCGOITCNSTZEHMS
GEUNOFTVQWHWSKXUTLERCQJRKCLAFZUMCSPRRCLATPYNRWFCUWTKTYUCMHIOIUNUEFVWODLVSNINEVVZJOTRDXADIXDGEFTJXIWAN
XJBALCFCVIFEUVICMSJJLEFGKXYNKIEVFUWNTUUNVEWVYCLIMUHEKSDQANWTFDYMTUUYYSMNZJSEXFZSCEFCPQHDKTIQNEYITSIOJDZ
DUTAOE

Caesar: line ?

Explanation:

Affine: line ?

Explanation:

Vigenère: line 6

Explanation: After identifying Playfair (line 1) and OTP (lines 3 and 4), the remaining candidates are lines 2, 5, and 6. Caesar and Affine are monoalphabetic, so their IC should stay close to English. Vigenère is polyalphabetic, so its IC should drop toward a random string.

Steps.

1. Compute the unnormalized IC

$$\kappa = \sum_i \frac{n_i(n_i - 1)}{N(N - 1)}.$$

2. Multiply by 26 so the values can be compared with Wikipedia's official figures:
English ≈ 1.73 , uniform random = 1.00.

3. Results for the three remaining lines:

- Line 2: $0.06878 \times 26 = 1.79$
- Line 5: $0.06472 \times 26 = 1.68$
- Line 6: $0.04308 \times 26 = 1.12$

4. Lines 2 and 5 are both near 1.73, so they are Caesar or Affine. Line 6 differs most from 1.73 and is closest to 1.00, therefore it is Vigenère.

Playfair: line 1

Explanation: Line 1 is the only ciphertext that contains no letter J. In this assignment, Playfair replaces every J with I and uses a 25-letter key that excludes J, so a Playfair ciphertext can never contain J. The other letter-only lines (2, 5, and 6) all contain J, so they cannot be Playfair.

OTP: lines 3, 4

Explanation: Lines 3 and 4 are the only ciphertexts that contain digits. The OTP in this assignment encodes letters as 5-bit symbols with the RFC 4648 Base32 alphabet (A–Z and 2–7), XORs them with the pad, and encodes the result back with the same alphabet. Therefore an OTP ciphertext can include the digits 2–7, whereas Caesar, Affine, Vigenère, and Playfair output only A–Z. This also matches the note that OTP was used twice.

3 Breaking Ciphers

[50 pts] Question 3 For each ciphertext, give the name of the Pokémon described in the plaintext and explain how you found it.

Caesar: Pokémon name

Explanation:

Affine: Pokémon name

Explanation:

Vigenère: Pokémon name

Explanation:

Playfair: Pokémon name

Explanation:

OTP (first line): Pokémon name

Explanation:

OTP (second line): Pokémon name

Explanation:

Generative AI Disclosure